ALLY WEALTH • AUTHOR VISIBILITY CONSULTANT

The Author’s Book Marketing Checklist

A practical planning system for building awareness, reader interest and a sustainable promotion rhythm.

A practical workbook and reference guide

EDUCATIONAL RESOURCE • 2026 EDITION

How to use this guide

A book marketing checklist is most useful when it turns a broad ambition—help more readers discover this book—into observable, manageable actions. This guide moves from foundations to launch preparation, campaign delivery and review. It is designed for independent authors and small publishing teams. It does not promise sales, rankings or reviews; it helps you plan deliberate work and learn from the response.

Work through the pages in order. Use the prompts to make decisions, record assumptions and identify actions. You can revisit a page when your book, audience or publishing plan changes.

Keep the work evidence-aware. Platform interfaces, policies and marketplace features change. Verify current official guidance before acting on platform-specific instructions. Treat examples as planning aids, not guarantees.

Make it your own. Not every tactic belongs in every campaign. Choose the actions that fit your book, resources, readers and values.

Contents

01	Start with the book’s purpose
02	Define the ideal reader
03	Position the book clearly
04	Audit the current book listing
05	Review the cover and thumbnail
06	Strengthen the book description
07	Prepare author information
08	Research categories and shelves
09	Research search phrases
10	Plan the campaign calendar
11	Create a simple campaign brief
12	Prepare promotional assets
13	Build an author platform
14	Use email thoughtfully
15	Approach reader communities respectfully
16	Plan advance reader outreach
17	Prepare launch-week actions
18	Coordinate series positioning
19	Promote beyond launch week
20	Track useful indicators
21	Keep a campaign log
22	Review the reader journey
23	Check accessibility and clarity
24	Manage budget and scope

25	Protect rights and permissions
26	Avoid misleading promotion
27	Prepare for delays
28	Conduct a 30-day review
29	Create the next 90-day plan
30	Your complete campaign checklist

01 / FIELD GUIDE

Start with the book’s purpose

Clarify what the book is, who it is for, and what you want marketing to achieve. Choose one primary objective for the next 90 days: discoverability, launch awareness, review outreach, series read-through, or a stronger author platform. A focused objective makes trade-offs easier.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **start with the book’s purpose**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

• What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?

• What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

02 / FIELD GUIDE

Define the ideal reader

Describe readers by interests, reading habits, genre expectations and the emotional experience they seek—not by vague labels such as everyone who likes books. Identify what those readers already read, watch, follow and discuss.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **define the ideal reader**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

- Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?
- What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?
- What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

03 / FIELD GUIDE

Position the book clearly

Write a one-sentence positioning statement that names the genre or category, the distinctive premise and the likely reader appeal. Check that the statement is accurate to the manuscript and does not promise a different reading experience.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **position the book clearly**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

- Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?
- What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?
- What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

04 / FIELD GUIDE

Audit the current book listing

Review the title, subtitle, description, cover, author details, categories, keywords, format options and sample experience. Record what is clear, what is missing and what may confuse a first-time visitor.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **audit the current book listing**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

• What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?

• What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

05 / FIELD GUIDE

Review the cover and thumbnail

Check the cover at full size and at small thumbnail scale. Genre cues, title legibility, contrast and visual hierarchy matter. Ask readers familiar with the category what they expect from the cover before commissioning changes.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **review the cover and thumbnail**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

- Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?
- What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?
- What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

06 / FIELD GUIDE

Strengthen the book description

Lead with a compelling reader-facing hook, then establish the central conflict, stakes or benefit. Keep the language specific, readable and faithful to the book. Avoid a plot summary that reveals too much or generic claims that could describe any title.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **strengthen the book description**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

• What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?

• What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

07 / FIELD GUIDE

Prepare author information

Create a concise author bio, a longer biography where needed, a consistent author photograph if desired, and a clear description of the themes or expertise relevant to the book. Keep details consistent across platforms.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **prepare author information**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

• What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?

• What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

08 / FIELD GUIDE

Research categories and shelves

Study how comparable books are presented in relevant store categories and reader spaces. Choose categories that accurately describe the book and match reader intent. Platform taxonomies and placement rules can change, so verify current options before submitting.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **research categories and shelves**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

• What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?

• What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

09 / FIELD GUIDE

Research search phrases

Build a reader-language list from the book’s genre, themes, setting, tropes, subject and comparable titles. Separate broad phrases from specific long-tail phrases. Do not add misleading terms simply because they appear popular.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **research search phrases**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

- Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?
- What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?
- What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

10 / FIELD GUIDE

Plan the campaign calendar

Work backwards from the publication or promotion date. Include preparation, announcement, outreach, launch-week activity, follow-up and review dates. Give each task an owner and a realistic completion date.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **plan the campaign calendar**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

- Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?
- What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?
- What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

11 / FIELD GUIDE

Create a simple campaign brief

Record the book facts, audience, positioning, key messages, approved images, links, dates, budget and boundaries. A shared brief prevents inconsistent descriptions and repeated clarification.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **create a simple campaign brief**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

• What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?

• What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

12 / FIELD GUIDE

Prepare promotional assets

Create a small, coherent set of assets: cover image, author image, short description, longer description, quote cards where rights permit, and format-specific graphics. Use readable typography and check every asset on mobile.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **prepare promotional assets**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

- Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?
- What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?
- What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

13 / FIELD GUIDE

Build an author platform

Choose channels where the intended readers already spend time. A useful platform is not a requirement to be everywhere. Define a sustainable posting rhythm and a clear next step for interested readers.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **build an author platform**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

• What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?

• What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

14 / FIELD GUIDE

Use email thoughtfully

If you have an opt-in list, send relevant updates with clear subject lines and a meaningful reason to open. Respect consent, provide an unsubscribe route and avoid adding people without permission.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **use email thoughtfully**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

- Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?
- What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?
- What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

15 / FIELD GUIDE

Approach reader communities respectfully

Observe community rules before participating. Contribute to conversations and share resources when welcome; do not flood groups with repetitive sales messages or treat communities as advertising inventory.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **approach reader communities respectfully**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

• What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?

• What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

16 / FIELD GUIDE

Plan advance reader outreach

Identify readers or reviewers whose interests align with the book. Explain the format, timing and expectations clearly. A request is an invitation, not an entitlement; reviews and positive opinions cannot be guaranteed.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **plan advance reader outreach**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

• What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?

• What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

17 / FIELD GUIDE

Prepare launch-week actions

Confirm links, formats, price information, page copy, assets and support contacts before launch. Plan a few coordinated actions rather than trying to publish everywhere at once.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **prepare launch-week actions**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

• What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?

• What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

18 / FIELD GUIDE

Coordinate series positioning

For a series, make reading order, book-to-book connections and entry points clear. Review covers, descriptions and metadata as a family while preserving each volume’s individual promise.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **coordinate series positioning**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

• What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?

• What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

19 / FIELD GUIDE

Promote beyond launch week

Create a post-launch plan that reuses useful content in fresh ways: reader questions, behind-the-scenes context, thematic posts, interviews or evergreen guides. Avoid assuming that attention ends after launch day.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **promote beyond launch week**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

• What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?

• What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

20 / FIELD GUIDE

Track useful indicators

Choose measures tied to the objective: listing visits where available, click-throughs, email engagement, qualified enquiries, reader responses or sales data you can access. Record the source and time period.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **track useful indicators**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

• What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?

• What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

21 / FIELD GUIDE

Keep a campaign log

For each activity, note the date, channel, audience, asset, cost, result and lesson. A log helps distinguish a promising pattern from a single unusual result.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **keep a campaign log**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

- Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?
- What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?
- What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

22 / FIELD GUIDE

Review the reader journey

Move through the path as a new reader: post or recommendation, book page, sample, purchase decision, author page and next book. Remove friction and resolve inconsistencies.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **review the reader journey**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

• What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?

• What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

23 / FIELD GUIDE

Check accessibility and clarity

Use readable type, adequate contrast, descriptive link text and alt text for meaningful images. Make essential information available in text rather than only inside graphics.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **check accessibility and clarity**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

• What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?

• What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

24 / FIELD GUIDE

Manage budget and scope

Set a spending ceiling and identify what is included in each supplier’s scope. Ask about deliverables, timelines, revision limits, reporting and ownership of finished assets.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **manage budget and scope**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

• What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?

• What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

25 / FIELD GUIDE

Protect rights and permissions

Confirm permission for cover art, photographs, quotations, music, testimonials and reader content. Keep records of licenses and approvals. Do not assume that online availability means reuse is allowed.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **protect rights and permissions**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

• What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?

• What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

26 / FIELD GUIDE

Avoid misleading promotion

Do not buy fake reviews, fabricate endorsements, misrepresent rankings or promise outcomes you cannot control. Be transparent about incentives and comply with platform rules and applicable law.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **avoid misleading promotion**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

- Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?
- What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?
- What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

27 / FIELD GUIDE

Prepare for delays

Build contingency time for file corrections, platform review, shipping, illness or asset revisions. Keep a short list of actions that can continue if one channel or platform is unavailable.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **prepare for delays**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

• What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?

• What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

28 / FIELD GUIDE

Conduct a 30-day review

Compare activity with the original objective. Identify what was completed, what produced useful signals, what was inconclusive and what should change. Treat the review as learning, not a verdict on the book.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **conduct a 30-day review**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

• What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?

• What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

29 / FIELD GUIDE

Create the next 90-day plan

Choose a small number of next actions based on evidence. Retire tactics that consume time without a plausible benefit, test one new approach and keep the reader experience central.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **create the next 90-day plan**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

- Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?
- What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?
- What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

30 / FIELD GUIDE

Your complete campaign checklist

Bring the plan together: audience, positioning, listing, assets, calendar, outreach, budget, measurement and review. Use this final page as a sign-off before a campaign begins.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **your complete campaign checklist**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

- Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?
- What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?
- What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes